

APPENDIX II

THE CHANT OF THE LESSONS

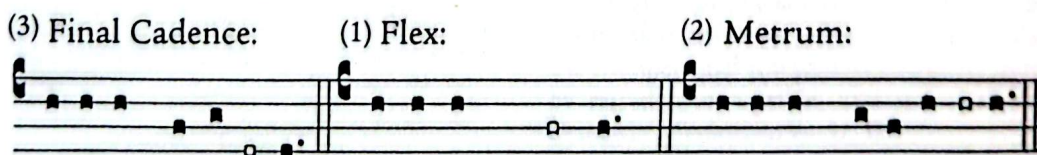
§ 1. *Why chant the Lessons at Matins and Evensong?*

IN the Prayer Book Daily Office, the Lessons are ordered to "be read distinctly with an audible voice, he that readeth so standing and turning himself as he may best be heard of all such as are present" (1662 English Prayer Book). Further, according to the direction of the 1549 Prayer Book, "to the end the people may the better hear, in such places where they do sing, there shall the Lessons be sung in a plain tune, after the manner of distinct reading."

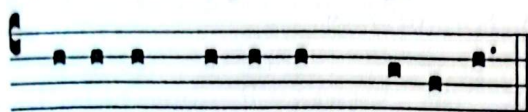
The foremost consideration in the reading out of the Lessons from Holy Scripture is that they may be understood, believed, and obeyed by the hearers. Lessons are sung for two reasons. One is to beautify the text by the artistry of music produced by the unaided voice. The other is to enhance the acoustical fidelity for the listeners. A Lesson sung with clear, crisp enunciation and suitable pauses, as well as with resonant projection of the voice, can be understood at a considerably greater distance than a spoken Lesson. And, as is so often the case with Plainchant, the chant itself serves to amplify the meaning of the sacred texts themselves, providing insight into deeper meanings of certain words than may be found in dictionaries and lexicons. A properly executed plainchant Office, just as with a properly executed High Mass, should (if at all possible) also include chanted Scriptural readings. Those Curates, Deacons and other clerks who are assigned to read the Lessons in parishes are strongly encouraged to learn and practice the following method.

§ 2. *Directions for Chanting the Lessons.*

THE most ancient Lesson Tone (originally devised for the Scriptural, Patristic and Hagiographical Lessons at Matins in the Roman Divine Office) has a pattern of notes identical with some of the Tones for the Epistle and Gospel at Mass. However, the intervals between pitches in the Lesson Tone are not the same as those in the Eucharistic formulae. Care must be taken that the intervals are sung as noted. Three melodic cadences are employed in the ancient Lesson Tone: (1) The *Flex*, (2) The *Metrum*, and (3) The *Final Cadence* (or, Full Stop):



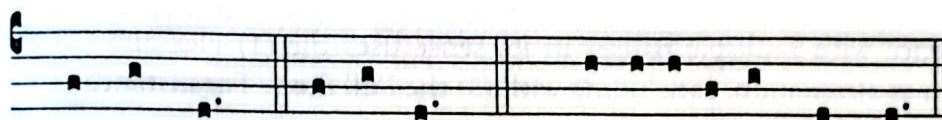
(The Metrum may also be sung:)



A short sentence with no natural pause in its meaning employs only (3), the Final Cadence (Full Stop). For instance:

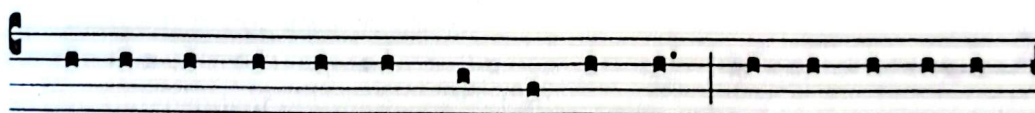


Even so, come Lord Jesus.¹ All of these were sons of Azel.² And

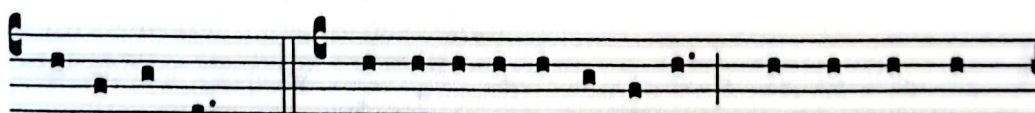


they sat down.³ Jesus wept.⁴ ... and a little lad with him.⁵

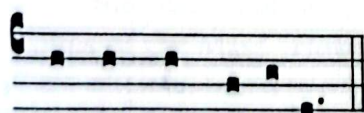
A sentence with one natural pause in its sense employs (2) the Metrum midway and (3) the Full Stop at the end. For instance:



But his wife look-ed back from behind him, and she became a



pillar of salt.⁶ Be not a terror unto me: thou art my hope



in the day of evil.⁷

1. Revelation xxii. 20.

2. I Chronicles viii. 38.

3. Ruth iv. 2.

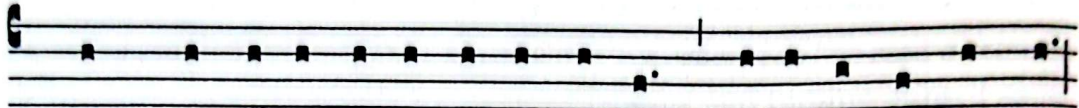
4. St. John xi. 35.

5. I Samuel xx. 35.

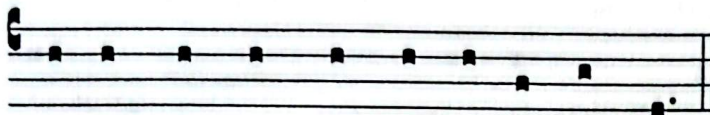
6. Genesis xix. 26.

7. Jeremiah xvii. 17.

A sentence with two natural pauses in its meanings uses first (1) the Flex, then (2) the Metrum, then (3) the Full Stop. For instance:

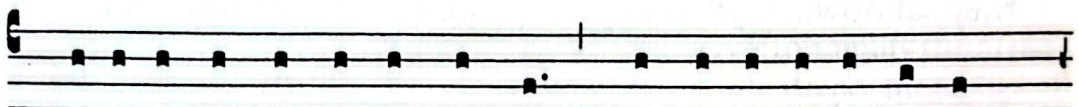


Grudge not one against another, brethren, lest ye be condemn-ed:

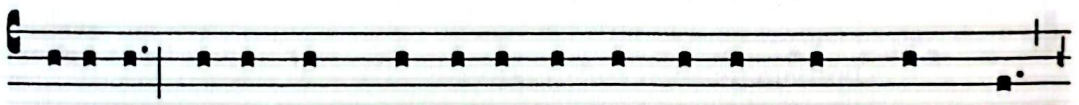


behold, the judge standeth before the door.⁸

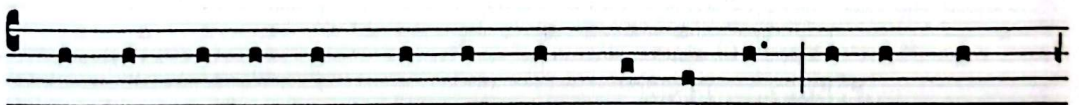
A sentence with multiple pauses in its sense uses the (1) Flex and (2) the Metrum in alternation, concluding with (3) the Full Stop. For instance:



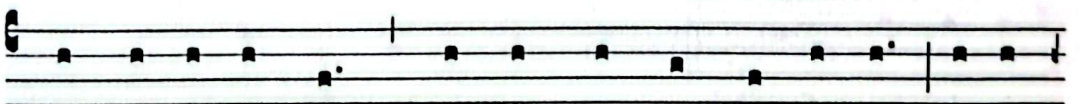
Moreover concerning the stranger, which is not of thy people



Is-ra-el, but is come from a far country for thy great name's sake,

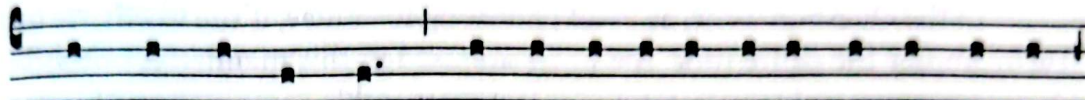


and thy mighty hand, and thy stretch-ed out arm; if they come

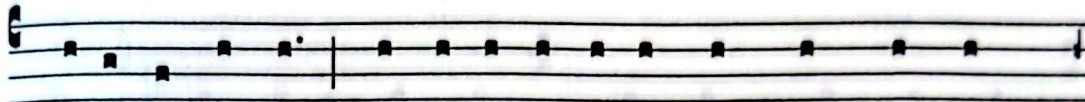


and pray in this house; then hear thou from the heavens, even

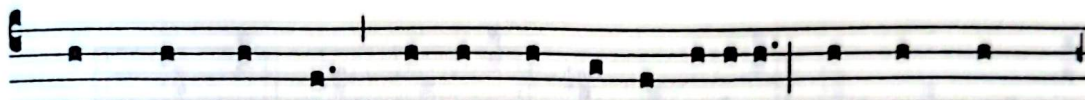
8. St. James v. 9.



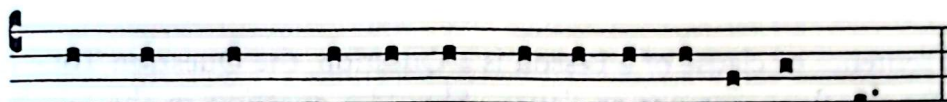
from thy dwelling place, and do according to all that the stranger



calleth to thee for; that all people of the earth may know thy



name, and fear thee, as doth thy people Israel, and may know

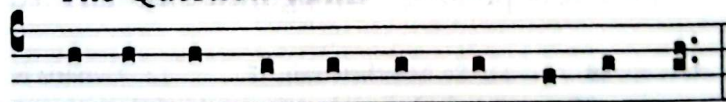


that this house which I have built is call-ed by thy name.⁹

The Metrum may be used without the Flex. But the Flex is not used if the Metrum is not used in the sentence. When the punctuation (usually a semi-colon or colon) separates independent clauses which, in meaning, stand as two independent sentences, each clause may be pointed as if a complete sentence. If the independent clauses of a compound sentence are closely tied in meaning, it may be preferable (for the sake of clarity for the listeners) not to point them as if they were free-standing sentences. In some cases, two or more independent clauses in a sentence are more readily comprehended if pointed as though they were separate sentences.

A special formula is applied to questions within the text. In the *Question Tone*, the pattern of notes is the same as in the Prophecy, Epistle and Gospel Tones of the Mass. However, the intervals between pitches are not the same. Care must be taken to sing the pitches as indicated by the notes.

The Question Tone:

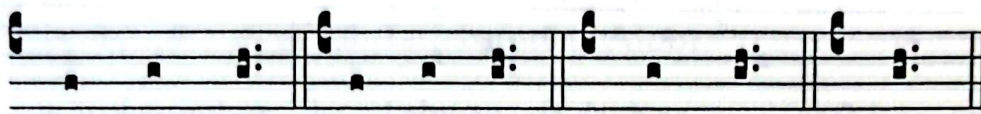


9. II Chronicles vi. 32, 33.

In the Question Tone, as in all plainsong formulae, if the words are too few to employ the entire tune, the notes are used in this manner: A one-syllable sentence uses only the last note (or last inseparable combination of notes) of the formula. A two-syllable sentence employs the last two notes, a three-syllable sentence employs the last three notes, and so on. For instance:

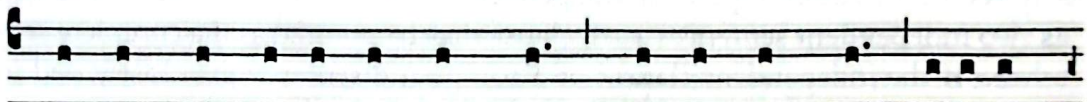


What house will ye build me? ¹⁰ What think ye of Christ? ¹¹ What

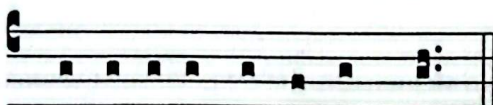


hast thou done? ¹² By what law? ¹³ What things? ¹⁴ What! ¹⁵

If the last sentence or clause of a Lesson is a Question, the Question Tone is not used for the final sentence or clause. Should a question in the text be unusually long, the Question Tone is not begun until rather near the end of the question, perhaps in the last clause or last section of words, lest the tonality be lost during the lengthy reciting note. Prior to that, the usual reciting note is sung. For instance:



Or who shut up the sea with doors, when it brake forth, as if it



had issued out of the womb? ¹⁶

In the course of singing that reciting note, the Metrum, if suitable, may be used. If the reciting note be prolonged enough, the Flex and Metrum may both

- | | | |
|---------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------|
| 10. Acts vii. 49. | 11. St. Matthew xxii. 17. | 12. Genesis iv. 10. |
| 13. Romans iii. 27. | 14. St. Luke xxiv. 19. | 15. I Corinthians vi. 19. |
| | 16. Job xxxviii. 8. | |

be employed. If the length of the recitation be extended longer yet, the Flex and Metrum may be alternated as many times as suits the text.

Finally, the conclusion, "Here endeth the First [or, Second] Lesson" is always spoken without note, parallel with the spoken "Here endeth the Epistle" in the Mass. This conclusion should not be said too hastily; but a short pause (perhaps two or three seconds) should be observed between the end of the Lesson and the conclusion.